

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 21

Culture (OWC): [Zulu \(FX20\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: Ca. 1956-1957

Coverage Date: Ca.1688-1957

Place Coverage

Nyuswa Reserve, KwaZulu-Natal Province, South Africa

Section Title(S)

DIAGRAM II Showing Patierns of House Affiliation

The most natural lines of segmentation, or, more correctly, of bifurcation in the lineage structure are along the "houses," i.e. along the lines which later divide the *imindeni yesisu*. The bifurcation does not lead to any total or permanent break between the members of the *imindeni yesisu*. Indeed they are still one lineage (*umndeni* or *usendo*). But the bifurcation makes for more efficient and more effective organization as the *umndeni* is too large and cumbersome to handle conveniently. These small *imindeni yesisu* have, as referends, their women founders. Thus, on Diagram I,^A we would have *umndeni wakwaMaKhuluse*, *umndeni wakwaMaMdina*, *umndeni wakwaMaMbokazi*, i.e. lineages of the womb of the MaKhuluse, MaMdima, and MaMbokazi "houses".

613
Lineages

The grandmother level is the most usual point at which the *umndeni wesisu* becomes distinctive and earns for itself a measure of independence and autonomy. This autonomy is never complete, however, as the *usendo* is still considered the supreme body to which all appeals from the *umndeni wesisu* are sent. Beyond the grandmother level, who becomes the eponym for the *umndeni wesisu*, the male founding ancestor becomes the referend, and the *umndeni* or *usendo* the main operating concept. Thus, for example, in Gogoda's lineage, Gogoda's family and descendants are all members of the *umndeni wesisu* of MaGwala, while the other collateral house in Gogoda's lineage is of the womb of MaNgcobo. But beyond this, they all refer to themselves as the children of Mlatsheni, i.e. Gogoda's grandfather.

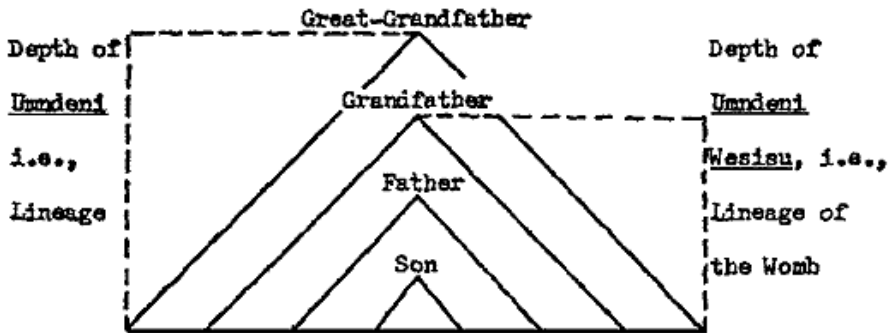
613
Lineages

The depth of the lineages and the lineages of the womb can be diagrammatically represented as follows:

613
Lineages

Diagram III

After E. E. Evans-Pritchard, in *The Nuer*, p. 106



As was pointed out earlier, very few commoners can go beyond their great-grandfather in tracing their genealogies. This means that only five generations are the depth of any **22**umndeni, the fifth generation being the grandchildren of the founding ancestors. For practical purposes of structural analysis, one finds that beyond this point the umndeni bonds fail to operate and no lineage relationships are recognized. It is at this point that people fall back on a mythical founder of the clan who is invoked as an explanation of their relationship. When asked about the basis of their relationship with others of the same surname (isibongo) they say: *siyazalana kodwa asidlelani*, i.e. we were begotten by the same ancestor but we do not eat together, which means, in other words, "we do not have any ritual bonds." Past this lineage point, the almost compulsive and near-pathological fear of incest ceases, as witness the jokes the people often indulge in. It is not uncommon to hear men describe actual or imaginary meetings with beautiful women of the same isibongo (surname) when the men were so overpowered that they ignored or changed their surnames to deceive the girls and had sex relations with them. We suggest that when the structural principles of kinship and the general social and ritual reciprocities are no more operative, when, in other words, people "do not eat together although descended from the same mythical ancestor", we have reached the clan stage of organization.

522
Humor

613
Lineages

614
Clans

835
Kinship Regulation Of Sex

A [See Category 613, p. 17—Analyst.]

Human Relations Area Files
755 Prospect Street
New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu
Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



